

Episode 1 — The Listener

Full Production Script · v1.0

From Pitch D v2.1 + external review lock conditions · conforms to Pilot Doctrine & writers' prompt v2 · 10 July 2026

"Her last message to the show has no words in it. Forty seconds of someone else in her house."

FORMAT CANON ESTABLISHED BY THIS EPISODE

The tip line: Echoes of Havenbay ends every episode with Ally reading out a voicemail number — "tell me what this city won't." The service is deliberately anonymising: it strips caller identity and keeps only audio and a timestamp, so sources can speak safely. This is why Ally cannot simply call Dot back, why Dot trusted the line mid-intrusion, and how future episodes arrive. **Episode temporality:** the show publishes *case alerts* — short rolling updates during an active investigation (L1, L5) — and a full episode after resolution (L12). Podcast-type leads are the recorded show; all other leads are events happening now.

LEAD STRUCTURE

#	ID	TYPE	TITLE	GATES	REQUIREMENT THEME	BAND / REWARD
1	e1_tip	Podcast · VO	The Tip Line	episode start → spawns 2, 3	forensic tools — the studio rig	Easy · 20
2	e1_forty	Evidence	The Forty Seconds	spawned by 1	forensic tools — taking the audio apart	Easy · 20
3	e1_archive	Data	Three Years of Goodnights	spawned by 1	fingerprint evidence — tagging the archive	Standard · 50
4	e1_bridge	Discuss (Gerald)	The Volume-Up	2 + 3	harbour/bar — a round at the Anchor	Standard · 50
5	e1_pod1	Podcast · VO	Case Alert: Dot Ellis	4 → spawns 6, 7, 8	forensic tools — cutting the alert	Milestone · 200 + 20 energy
6	e1_cottage	Evidence	The Cold Kettle	spawned by 5	fingerprint evidence — the house search	Hard · 95
7	e1_inspector	Interview	The Man Who Came at Noon	spawned by 5	diner food — doorstep coffee, Rivermouth	Standard · 50
8	e1_boats	Money Trail	The Quiet Boats	spawned by 5	harbour/bar — reading the river	Hard · 95

9	e1_delcruz	Interview · BRANCH	Off the Record	7 + 8	diner food — Del's lunch bench	Standard · 50
10	e1_trail	Data	Where Dot Went	6 + 9	forensic tools — the paper trail	Standard · 50
11	e1_hills	Location · CLIMAX	The Hill Cottage	10	harbour/bar — the drive through the fog	Very Hard · 185 + 2 ingots
12	e1_close	Podcast · VO	Goodnight, Harbour	11	fingerprint evidence — the episode master	Milestone · 500 + 20 energy + 3 ingots

Portrait speakers: Ally, Gerald, Dot (new — greenlit package). Mo, Del Cruz, the neighbour, Vera speak as quotes inside Ally's narration (canon portraits may upgrade Mo/Del later without script changes). Card subtitles and exact item/tier economy mapping happen at asset production. Flags: aq.lead.e1_.seen per lead; e1.phase1.complete on L5 Proceed; e1.ep01.complete on L12 Proceed; branch sets aq.e1.truth_public or aq.e1.truth_protected.*

PHASE 1

L1 · E1_TIP — "THE TIP LINE" (PODCAST, VO)

Cold open. Dot speaks first. Node 2 is the SFX node — the caption is on-screen text (accessibility by construction); the audio asset is the mix. VO directions in italics.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Dot (voicemail)	happy	<i>[warm, amused, unhurried]</i> It's Dot from Rivermouth, love. Nothing worth troubling you with — the gulls held a parliament on my roof, and the quiet boats went by twice. Say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally.
2	Tip line — 3:04 a.m.	—	[The final message plays. Forty seconds, no words. A floorboard, twice. The slow spring of a back door. Far off, a diesel engine, ticking over. Then nothing.]
3	Ally	neutral	<i>[polished host voice, fatigue underneath]</i> My show has a voicemail line. End of every episode I read the number out and say: tell me what this city won't. Most callers bring theories. Dot brought the harbour — three years of goodnights, and her blessing to play the best of them.
4	Ally	sad	<i>[remorse leaking through restraint]</i> Three nights ago she left the message you just heard. No words. She opened the line and let the house speak for her — to the one number she trusted to listen. It waited three days for me to press play. I was busy making a show about listening.
5	Ally	neutral	<i>[resolve; returning to host register]</i> Dot, if you can hear this: goodnight, the harbour misses you. Everyone else — this is Echoes of Havenbay. The tip line is open. This week, it's mine to answer.

L2 · E1_FORTY — "THE FORTY SECONDS" (EVIDENCE)

Ally's competence beat. The limp is an observation, not a certainty — confirmed visually at L7.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	You can't un-hear a message like that. But you can take it apart. Tonight the studio floor belongs to the forty seconds — one sound at a time, until the room gives up its story.
2	Ally	neutral	A floorboard, twice — inside the hall, not the porch. The spring of her back door, stretched slow, the way you open a door you don't want heard. And outside, far off, a diesel. Ticking over. Waiting for somebody.
3	Ally	surprised	The steps are the tell. Eight of them, unhurried — and one lands harder than the other, every second step. I can't tell you he limps. I can tell you the house does, when he walks through it.
4	Ally	neutral	Somebody moved through Dot's house at three in the morning, slow and patient, while she kept a line open and her mouth shut. She was braver in forty seconds than most of us manage in a year. Now let's find her street.

L3 · E1_ARCHIVE — "THREE YEARS OF GOODNIGHTS" (DATA)

The archive as evidence corpus. Establishes Dot's on-air permission (culpability calibration), her dry humour, and the recent trigger.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Three years of messages, most under a minute. I used to pick one to close the show — Dot knew, and Dot loved it. "Play the one about the gulls," she told me once. "I was very good in that one."
2	Ally	neutral	Tonight they're not a closing segment. They're a map. A school bell, always faint, always east. Gulls in the morning messages, never the night ones. And under the late calls, a low mechanical note, every twenty-odd seconds — like the city breathing.
3	Ally	worried	And the boats. She's mentioned them for years the way you'd mention weather. But three weeks ago the message changed: "the pretty one came close tonight — two-note horn, no lights, and a funny mark on the funnel, like a fish-hook." Three weeks ago, I played that one on the show.
4	Ally	neutral	Somewhere in this city is a street with a school bell to the east, gulls at sunrise, and a machine that breathes every twenty seconds. Gerald has heard every machine Havenbay ever built. Time to buy my grandfather a drink.

L4 · E1_BRIDGE — "THE VOLUME-UP" (DISCUSS — GERALD, THE RUSTY ANCHOR)

Gerald's engineered entrance: process shown, deduction earned. Mo's city-memory cameo closes it.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	The Rusty Anchor, Tuesday-quiet. Mo had the corner booth held before I asked — she does that. I handed Gerald the headphones and told him what was on them. He didn't flinch. He turned the volume up.
2	Gerald	neutral	Loop the low note for me, love. Just that. Nothing else in my ears.
3	Ally	neutral	I looped it. He counted under his breath, pencil ticking the table — an old detective keeping time with a machine across town. Then he took the headphones off, and he had it. Twenty-two seconds.
4	Gerald	worried	Swing-bridge counterweight, Rivermouth reach — the old crossing sings when boats run late. Your Dot lives near enough to hear the river breathe. So did the man in her hall. Mind how you go down there, love.
5	Ally	neutral	On the way out, Mo leaned over with two words and a postcode's worth of memory: "Dot Ellis. Cleaned the school on Chandler Street thirty years — tell her Tuesday quiz misses her." Nobody the city forgets stays forgotten at the Anchor. Chandler Street. We're close.

L5 · E1_POD1 — "CASE ALERT: DOT ELLIS" (PODCAST, VO — MILESTONE)

Rolling case-alert format. Del's refusal pre-seeded. Fires e1.phase1.complete on Proceed.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	<i>[host register, steadier than she feels]</i> This is Echoes of Havenbay, with a case alert. Her name is Dot Ellis. For three years she said goodnight to this show. Days ago, someone walked through her house at three in the morning — and she hasn't been heard from since.
2	Ally	neutral	Her own messages found her street: Chandler Road, Rivermouth — a school bell to the east, a swing-bridge for a heartbeat. Her last message found him: eight slow footsteps that don't belong, a back door, an engine waiting in the lane.
3	Ally	worried	Police can't open a file on a voice going quiet — I've been told, politely, twice. So we do what this show does. We knock on Rivermouth's doors ourselves. If you knew Dot Ellis, the tip line is open, and it keeps no names.
4	Ally	neutral	<i>[quiet steel; directly to one listener]</i> One more thing, for whoever needs to hear it. She made it out her back door. You were eight steps too slow. So far, so am I. That changes this week.

PHASE 2

L6 · E1_COTTAGE — "THE COLD KETTLE" (EVIDENCE)

The coin, and Gerald's pencil-stop rendered in text. Dot's agency: she packed, she chose.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Eleven Chandler Road. A blue gate, a garden kept the way you keep a promise, mail three days deep — and the spare key exactly where her generation always leaves it. I let myself in. Forgive me, Dot.
2	Ally	sad	Kettle cold. Bed made. Reading glasses gone, coat gone, the little case she took to church gone. She packed — quick, in the dark, but she packed. You don't pack for the river. She's alive somewhere, and she chose the somewhere.
3	Ally	surprised	The hall table: her phone charger, empty — phone gone with her, smart girl. And sitting dead centre on the cradle, where the phone should sleep, a coin. Old brass, worn smooth. Placed. Not dropped.
4	Ally	worried	I photographed it for Gerald. Watched three dots appear and disappear, twice. Then, no question mark: "Where was it." — "On her phone cradle." A full minute of nothing. Then: "Don't put that on the show, love."
5	Ally	neutral	I have heard my grandfather discuss murders with his mouth full. I have never heard him go quiet. The coin goes in an evidence bag, and the bag goes in the drawer, and the drawer stays shut. Back to work.

L7 · E1_INSPECTOR — "THE MAN WHO CAME AT NOON" (INTERVIEW)

The neighbour + doorbell footage. Audio observation → visual confirmation. Intruder's objective concrete; intent stays unknown.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Rivermouth doors open for coffee and a box from the Corner Diner — they pack it heavy when they hear why. Four houses in, a neighbour remembered him: a gas man, ten days back, credentials on a lanyard. No company. Nobody scheduled him.
2	Ally	surprised	Her doorbell camera kept eleven seconds of him. Tall. Careful. Face angled off-lens like a man who's had practice. And there it is, plain as the audio guessed: every second step lands heavier. The house wasn't imagining. He limps.
3	Ally	worried	He went to Dot's door first. Twenty minutes inside, in daylight, with a lanyard for a spell — checking what her window could see, I'd bet my rig on it. Ten days later he came back in the dark, for whatever she'd kept of it.
4	Ally	neutral	Whether he came to frighten her, or silence her, or worse — I don't get to know that yet, and neither do you. What I know is this: he plans, he comes back, and he's on camera. Eleven seconds of him is more than he ever meant anyone to have.

L8 · E1_BOATS — "THE QUIET BOATS" (MONEY TRAIL)

The midpoint inversion. Ally's single *angry* — the episode's one use, earned.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Back to the archive, with worse eyes. Every mention of the boats, three years of them, laid end to end. Low in the water going out. Riding high coming back. No lights. No horn — except once.
2	Ally	neutral	Insomnia made Dot a scientist. Same window, same hours, decades of nights. She wasn't spying on anyone — she just knew what belonged on her river, the way you know your own stairs in the dark. And she said hello to what didn't.
3	Ally	surprised	Three weeks ago: the pretty one, close in. Two-note horn. A fish-hook mark on the funnel. I played it on the show with her blessing and thought it was charming. Somebody heard it who knows exactly what a fish-hook on a funnel means.
4	Ally	angry	<i>[cold, precise fury — not raised voice]</i> He didn't find Dot's window by luck. I read it to him. Episode forty-one, closing minute, my voice, her view. He isn't just watching her house. He's a listener. He has heard every goodnight she ever sent me — and everything I've said since.

L9 · E1_DELCRUZ — "OFF THE RECORD" (INTERVIEW — THE BRANCH)

Del Cruz's engineered entrance, then the episode's choice. Node 4 is the choice node; 5a/5b are path nodes (each sets its truth flag); node 6 converges. The flag surfaces on the case summary screen: PUBLIC TRUTH / PROTECTED TRUTH.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Sergeant Del Cruz, Harbor Ward, on her lunch break, off the record — her choice of bench, back to the water. I laid it all out: the forty seconds, the inspector, the coin I've been told not to broadcast.
2	Ally	neutral	"You don't have an address she's at, a relative reporting her, or a crime I can name," she said, and let that sit for exactly one bite. Then: "Send me the recording." She wrote a case number on a napkin. Unofficial — like everything in this city that works.
3	Ally	worried	Then the question that cuts this episode in half. The forty seconds — his footsteps, his engine. Put them on the feed, and ten thousand ears go hunting a limp and a diesel. And one particular listener learns exactly how much I have.
4	Ally	neutral	Del watched me weigh it and gave me nothing but the truth: "Your show, your call. But whatever you choose — choose it out loud." <i>CHOICE ① Release the forty seconds — let the city hunt with us ② Hold them back — hunt quiet, keep him blind</i>
5a	Ally	neutral	<i>(path: sets aq.e1.truth_public)</i> We published. The sound of a man being somewhere he shouldn't be, on ten thousand phones by midnight. The queue flooded — one mechanic who knew that engine's tick, and a hundred and ninety-nine ghosts to sift. Loud truth. It costs in noise. It pays in reach.
5b	Ally	neutral	<i>(path: sets aq.e1.truth_protected)</i> We held it. Del's copy went where mine can't — quiet checks on registered diesels, a gait run against old harbour footage. The queue stayed calm, and he stayed blind to what we hold. Quiet truth. It costs in patience. It pays in surprise.
6	Ally	neutral	<i>(converge)</i> Either way, something travels with me now, printed where I'll see it on every case to come: how you tell the truth is also who you are. Dot's still out there. Next question — how does a frightened woman with a church case leave town without her car?

L10 · E1_TRAIL — "WHERE DOT WENT" (DATA)

Branch-variant node 2 (requiresFlag per path) delivers the same concrete victory by different roads: the Harbourline trace. Sister introduced here — never earlier.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	The cottage told us she left; now it tells us where. A pharmacy bag folded flat in the kitchen drawer — a hill-town name on the label. A parish newsletter on the mantel, posted to two addresses. Dot kept everything. Thank God for a generation that keeps everything.
2a	Ally	surprised	<i>(requires aq.e1.truth_public)</i> And the queue paid its way through the noise: a mechanic placed that engine's tick — a Harbourline diesel. Port-security fleet, dissolved in 2011. A dead company, still driving. The false sightings cost us a day. The engine has a name now.
2b	Ally	surprised	<i>(requires aq.e1.truth_protected)</i> And Del paid out quiet: the doorbell frame matches a van logged near the docks — registered to Harbourline. Port-security firm, dissolved in 2011. A dead company, still driving. And nobody knows we know. The engine has a name now.
3	Ally	neutral	The newsletter's second address sits exactly where the pharmacy bus stops: a hill town with one church and one street. The sister Dot mentioned twice in three years — once at Christmas, once like an apology. Vera. I'm driving up at first light.

L11 · E1_HILLS — "THE HILL COTTAGE" (LOCATION — CLIMAX)

The tension beat, the reunion, the reckoning. Dot's portrait debuts in person. Her *angry* is hers — the script's second and last use, deliberately one per character, both earned.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	worried	Fog all the way up — the kind that swallows headlights whole. I found the church, the street, the cottage with lace curtains. And before I saw anything at all, I heard it: a diesel, idling, somewhere behind the white.
2	Ally	worried	The front door stood open. Open — in the fog, in the cold, in a town where nobody locks up because nobody comes. I was through the gate with my heart in my ears, calling her name into somebody's silent hallway—
3	Dot	neutral	You always did make a production of things. I heard the gate. Vera heard the gate. The church heard the gate. Close the door, love — you're letting the hill in.
4	Dot	angry	And before you say sorry, say it properly: you turned my window into a broadcast, Ally Quinn. My river. My own silly voice, out where anyone could hear it. — And I still called your line that night. You know why? I knew you'd hear it. Eventually.
5	Ally	sad	The diesel faded down the hill road while Vera put the kettle on — a farmer, maybe. Maybe. I didn't say sorry, in the end. I said goodnight, the way she taught me. She's safe tonight. "Tonight" is doing a lot of work in that sentence.

L12 · E1_CLOSE — "GOODNIGHT, HARBOUR" (PODCAST, VO — MILESTONE)

Resolution on Dot's terms; the concrete victory consolidated; the sign-off ritual completed; the stinger. Fires e1.ep01.complete on Proceed → spawns cold cases + Ep2 teaser.

SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1 Ally	neutral	[host register, warmer than episode one's start] This is Echoes of Havenbay. Dot Ellis is safe — found by her own breadcrumbs: a pharmacy bag, a parish newsletter, thirty years of saying goodnight to the right person. She declined an interview. Her words: "I'm not content, love. I'm a person."
2 Ally	neutral	What we know, on the record: a man with a careful walk entered her home, behind a diesel that belongs to Harbourline Security — dissolved in 2011, still driving. That name goes in a drawer that is getting heavier. Next to a coin I was asked not to show you.
3 Ally	worried	[measured; speaking to one listener] What I know, off the record: he found her window through me. This show is built on listening. This case taught me who else does. To the man with the careful walk — the forty seconds are safe. So is she. You're the only one still hiding.
4 Dot (voicemail)	happy	[warm; the ritual, reclaimed] It's Dot. From the hills now — imagine that. Vera says hello, which for Vera is a parade. You found an old woman who didn't want a fuss and you made one anyway. Good girl. Say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally.
5 Ally	neutral	[the whole episode in six words, then the promise] Goodnight, Dot. Goodnight, harbour. — The tip line stays open.
6 —	—	[Somewhere: this episode, playing. A click. Silence. A diesel engine starts.]

LOCK-CONDITION CHECKLIST (EXTERNAL REVIEW, ALL 12)

CONDITION	WHERE ADDRESSED
1 · Anonymous caller metadata	Format canon: tip line strips identity, keeps audio + timestamp (established L1n3 "it keeps no names" at L5n3).
2 · Dot's phone / why uncontactable	L6n3: phone gone with her, charger empty; anonymised line means no number to call. Coin placed on the cradle = meaningful clue.
3 · Timeline repaired	Option A: message three nights old, heard "this morning" (L1n4); guilt kept via the three-day queue.
4 · No premature sister knowledge	Sister absent from the opening; introduced L10n3 via the newsletter's second address.
5 · Intruder's concrete objective	L7n3: daylight = sightline check; 3 a.m. = retrieve what she'd kept. Trigger: the aired fish-hook message (L3n3/L8n3).
6 · Never declare him harmless	L7n4: "frighten, silence, or worse — I don't get to know that yet."

7 · Climax tension beat	L11n1–2: idling diesel in fog, open door, dread — then Dot from behind. Diesel "maybe a farmer. Maybe." Safety provisional (L11n5).
8 · One concrete victory	Harbourline Security trace (L10n2a/2b, consolidated L12n2) — season-feeding, path-flavoured.
9 · Branch materially changes Phase 2	Distinct L9 path nodes with costs stated; distinct L10 evidence roads; PUBLIC/PROTECTED TRUTH flag surfaced on case summary.
10 · First-five-minutes gameplay	Pacing targets adopted in-engine: Dot's voice first, L1 completes in FTUE, L2's merge goal framed as cleaning the audio. (No new UI surfaces — v1 constraint.)
11 · Non-audio accessibility	By construction: every sound is on-screen text (nodes 1–2 captions, all clue descriptions written); VO/SFX additive only.
12 · Final line	"Goodnight, Dot. Goodnight, harbour. — The tip line stays open." Defiant quip cut; stinger answers through sound instead.

PRODUCTION NOTES

- **Node count:** 54 including branch variants (48 on any single playthrough). Within budget.
- **Portraits (greenlit package):** Dot Ellis is the one required new face (7-emotion set; priority neutral/happy/angry). Mo, Del Cruz upgrades slot in later without script changes — their lines are quoted inside Ally narration.
- **VO assets:** Ally — all Podcast leads (L1, L5, L12; ~13 nodes). Dot — 3 voicemail nodes (one new voice). SFX set: the forty-seconds mix + isolated floorboard/door-spring/diesel/footsteps + bridge-note loop + the stinger. Five short Dot archive clips maximum; the wider archive is implied.
- **Emotion enums** drive portraits; bracketed VO directions are for the recording session only and are stripped from game data.
- **New canon on approval:** Dot Ellis & Vera; the anonymising tip line + case-alert format; Chandler Road/Rivermouth swing-bridge; Harbourline Security (dissolved 2011); the fish-hook funnel mark; episode 41's closing segment. The coin, quiet boats, and Harbourline all feed Episode 2 (The Ferryman) — its "you found the ghost student" callback must be re-pointed to "you found Dot Ellis."
- **Angry-emotion accounting:** two uses, one per character (Ally L8n4, Dot L11n4), both load-bearing. Deliberate, documented exception to the one-per-episode guidance.
- **Cold cases re-point:** the three Cold Case leads + Ep2 teaser move their spawn hook from `gs_case_close` to `e1_close` during asset production.